

Hume's *Distinctio Rationis*

Bridger Ehli

The *Treatise* frequently discusses thoughts that are, by its own principles, unattainable. For example, Hume considers the idea of a vacuum, understood as extension ‘where there is nothing visible or tangible’, although the existence of that idea would be inconsistent with his claim that every idea of extension is an idea of an array of visible or tangible points (*T* 1.2.5.1).¹ Likewise, he considers the idea of causal necessity, understood as a property in virtue of which one is ‘able to pronounce, from a simple view of the [cause], that it must be follow’d or preceded by the [effect]’, although the existence of that idea would be inconsistent with his claim that we never perceive necessary connections between distinct objects (*T* 1.3.14.13). In such cases, Hume’s strategy is to identify an illusion that leads us to suppose we have thoughts that, in fact, we do not have. These are of a piece with the *Treatise*’s skeptical ambitions, implying that certain cognitive achievements are chimerical. I argue that this strategy is present in Hume’s account of rational distinction.

Traditionally, rational distinctions are distinctions between items that are, in reality, inseparable. Descartes’s leading example is the distinction between a substance and its duration: ‘since substance cannot cease to endure without also ceasing to be, the distinction between substance and its duration is a merely rational one’ (AT VIIIA 30/CSM I 214).² Such distinctions are puzzling by Hume’s lights because they are *prima facie* inconsistent with his *separability principle*: ‘whatever objects are different are distinguishable, and . . . whatever objects are distinguishable are separable by the thought and imagination’, where these claims are ‘equally true in the *inverse*’ (*T* 1.1.7.3). The principle holds, in the first place, that items are distinct if and only if

¹ References to Hume’s works are to the editions given at the front of the volume. *A Treatise of Human Nature* is cited as *T* followed by book, part, section, and, where appropriate, paragraph numbers; ‘App’ and ‘Abs’ refer, respectively, to the Appendix and Abstract of *T*. The first *Enquiry* is cited as *EHU* followed by section and paragraph numbers.

² CSM translates *distinctio rationis* as ‘conceptual distinction’.

they are distinguishable if and only if they are separable in thought.³ Further, because ‘whatever we conceive is possible,’ separability in thought implies separability in reality: the possibility of each item’s existing without the other (T 1.4.5.10). Hume accepts that distinguishability, distinctness, and separability in thought and in reality are mutually entailing.⁴ The separability principle appears to imply that rational distinctions are impossible because they require distinction without the possibility of separation.

The *Treatise’s* discussion of rational distinction addresses three questions. First, what are rational distinctions? This question frames the closing paragraphs of T 1.1.7: ‘What then is meant by a distinction of reason, since it implies neither a difference nor separation?’ (T 1.1.7.17). Second, how do we draw rational distinctions? Third, how, if at all, is our drawing them consistent with the separability principle? There is no consensus with respect to what Humean rational distinctions are distinctions between. Commentators have variously held that Humean rational distinctions are distinctions between inseparable aspects of an object, between an object’s resemblances, or between general ideas.⁵ Further, some but not all commentators hold that

³ In his initial statement of the separability principle, Hume says that difference implies distinguishability and separability in thought. See also T 1.1.7.17, 1.2.3.10, 1.4.5.5, and 1.4.6.3. He also applies the principle in terms of distinctness. See T 1.3.3.3, 1.3.6.1, and 1.4.5.5. I frame the principle in terms of the latter. Section 4 argues that distinctness and difference are, in the sense salient to the separability principle, equivalent to numerical non-identity.

⁴ I use ‘separability principle’ to refer to the conjunction of what Baxter calls the *mental separability principle* and what he calls the *real separability principle*. See Donald Baxter, ‘Hume, Distinctions of Reason, and Differential Resemblance’ [‘Differential Resemblance’], *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research*, 82 (2011), 156–82, at 161–3. The mental separability and conceivability principles imply the real separability principle in conjunction with the claim that separability in reality requires distinctness. Qu argues that the notion of distinguishability to which the separability principle appeals is *in-principle* distinguishability: items are distinguishable just in case there is some qualitative or relational difference between them. See Hsueh Qu, ‘Complex Ideas and Hume’s Separability Principle’ [‘Complex Ideas’], *Mind*, 131 (2022), 517–34, at 519.

⁵ Those who accept that rational distinctions are distinctions between aspects or respects include Don Garrett, *Cognition and Commitment in Hume’s Philosophy* [Cognition and Commitment] (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1997), 63; Tito Magri, *Hume’s Imagination* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2022), 135; Maurice Mandelbaum, ‘The Distinguishable and the Separable: A Note on Hume and Causation’ [‘Distinguishable and Separable’], *Journal of the History of Philosophy*, 12 (1974), 242–7, at 245; Janet Broughton, ‘Explaining General Ideas’, *Hume Studies*, 26 (2000), 279–89, at 284; and Michael Della Rocca, ‘Playing with Fire: Hume, Rationalism, and a Little Bit of Spinoza’ [‘Playing with Fire’], in Michael Della Rocca (ed.), *The Oxford Handbook of Spinoza* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017), 464–81, at 473. Durland holds that drawing a rational distinction involves forming new, distinct simple ideas of ‘features or aspects’ of an object. See Karánn Durland, ‘Hume’s First Principle, His Missing Shade, and His Distinctions of Reason’ [‘First Principle’], *Hume Studies*, 22 (1996), 105–21, at 112–13. Qu considers the view that general ideas are the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions. See Hsueh Qu, ‘Type Distinctions of Reason and Hume’s Separability Principle’ [‘Type Distinctions’], *British Journal for the History of Philosophy*, 28 (2020), 90–111, at 94. Okamura argues that rational distinctions are distinctions between resemblance relations. See Taro Okamura, ‘Hume

the process by which rational distinctions are drawn is to be understood in terms of Hume's theory of general ideas. There is also disagreement regarding whether Hume restricts the scope of the separability principle so that it does not apply to the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions.⁶

I offer a new account of Humean rational distinctions. The contrast between the question of what rational distinctions are and the question of how they are drawn is, by Hume's lights, misleading. What is meant by 'distinction of reason' is a cognitive process. This process produces the illusion that distinctions between inseparable items are possible.⁷ I begin by surveying early modern contributions to the metaphysics of distinction (Section 1). Next, I give an overview of the process by which Humean rational distinctions are drawn (Section 2). I then consider several identifications of the *distinguenda* of Humean rational distinctions, arguing that none is satisfactory (Section 3). Finally, I argue that Hume takes the answer to the question 'what is meant by a distinction of reason?' to be the cognitive process considered in *T* 1.1.7 (Section 4).

1. Real, Modal, and Rational

In the entry for 'Distinction' in the *Cyclopædia*, Chambers claims that there are 'three kinds of Distinctions, taken from the different Modes of Existence'.⁸

on Distinctions of Reason: A Resemblance-First Interpretation' ['Distinctions of Reason'], *Australasian Journal of Philosophy*, 97 (2019), 423–36, at 431.

⁶ Hakkarainen claims that 'Hume thinks that the separability principle does not apply to distinctions of reason'. See Jani Hakkarainen, 'A Third Type of Distinction in the *Treatise*' ['Third Type of Distinction'], *Hume Studies*, 38 (2012), 55–78, at 62. Kemp Smith claims that distinctions of reason are 'distinctions which imply neither difference nor separation'. See Norman Kemp Smith, *The Philosophy of David Hume* (New York: Macmillan, 1941), 265. Mandelbaum, 'Distinguishable and Separable', 245, writes that 'Hume's axiom that what is distinguishable is separable holds only in relation to what results from acts of thought and imagination; it is not properly construed as a description of what is given in experience'. See also John Bricke, *Hume's Philosophy of Mind* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1980), 71. Garrett, *Cognition and Commitment*, 64, holds that the intended scope of the separability principle includes only objects and perceptions. Bracken argues that Hume's separability principle is inconsistent with his account of distinctions of reason. See Harry Bracken, 'Hume on the "Distinction of Reason"', *Hume Studies*, 10 (1984), 89–108, at 98–9.

⁷ My reading is similar to Brand's, according to which rational distinction involves the 'mistaken belief' that we are considering separately things that are inseparable, although he holds that rational distinctions track 'different aspects of simple ideas'. See Walter Brand, *Hume's Theory of Moral Judgment* (Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1992), 13. Qu, 'Complex Ideas', 520n, suggests but does not develop the view that rational distinctions are not 'genuine distinctions'.

⁸ Ephraim Chambers, 'Distinction', in *Cyclopædia: Or, an Universal Dictionary of Arts and Sciences*, 2 vols. (London: Printed for William Innys et al., 1728).

They are *real distinction*, *modal distinction*, and *rational distinction*. The same list appears in Descartes's *Principles*. For Descartes, a distinction between two substances is a real distinction (AT VIIIA 24/CSM I 210). A distinction between a mode and its substance is a modal distinction (AT VIIIA 29/CSM I 214).⁹ A rational distinction is either 'a distinction between a substance and some attribute of that substance without which the substance is unintelligible [*intelligi non potest*]' or 'a distinction between two such attributes of a single substance' (AT VIIIA 30/CSM I 214).

This suggests a schema: x and y are separable just in case x can exist without y 's existing or y can exist without x 's existing. Their separability is symmetric just in case each can exist without the other's existing. Their separability is asymmetric just in case one but not both can exist without the other's existing. If x and y are symmetrically separable, then x and y are really distinct. If x and y are asymmetrically separable, then x and y are modally distinct. If x and y are neither symmetrically nor asymmetrically separable, then x and y are rationally distinct.¹⁰ Chambers endorses this explicitly: a real distinction is a distinction 'between Things which may exist . . . a-part'; a modal distinction is a distinction 'between several Things one whereof may exist without the other, but not *vice versa*'; and a rational distinction is a distinction 'between several Things, which are really one and the same, and whereof one cannot exist without the other, nor *vice versa*'. Unless otherwise noted, I use 'separable' to mean 'symmetrically separable in reality' and 'inseparable' to mean 'neither symmetrically nor asymmetrically separable in reality'. Items are symmetrically separable in thought just in case it is conceivable that each should exist without the other's existing; items are symmetrically separable in reality just in case it is possible that each should exist without the other's existing.

In a 1645/6 letter, Descartes claims that a rational distinction is 'a distinction made by reason *ratiocinatae*' (AT IV 349/CSMK 280). He continues: 'I do not recognize any distinction made by reason *ratiocinantis*—that is, one which has no foundation in reality [*fundamentum in rebus*]'—because we cannot have any thought without a foundation; and consequently in [the

⁹ I set aside two complications in Descartes's theory of distinction. First, two modes of really distinct substances are themselves really distinct (AT VIIIA 30/CSM I 214). Second, there is a modal distinction between two modes of the same substance (AT VIIIA 30/CSM I 214).

¹⁰ Hoffman argues that Descartes denies that, for any x and any y , if x and y are inseparable, then x and y are rationally distinct. See Paul Hoffman, 'Descartes's Theory of Distinction', *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research*, 64 (2002), 57–78, at 60. On Hoffman's reading, inseparability implies rational distinction only with non-identity.

Principles] I did not add the term *ratiocinatae*' (AT IV 349–50/CSMK 280). Cartesian rational distinction corresponds to the distinction of *reasoned* reason, not of *reasoning* reason. This distinction receives discussion in the seventh of Suárez's *Metaphysical Disputations*, 'Of the Various Genera of Distinctions'. Suárez introduces rational distinctions as those that 'are not formally and actually in the things, which are thus denominated as distinct, as they exist in themselves, but only as they exist in our concepts' (DM 7.1.4/OO XXV 251).¹¹ Distinctions of reasoning reason have no foundation *in re* and result only from the 'activity [*negotatione*] and operation of reason' (DM 7.1.4/OO XXV 251). Distinctions of reasoned reason, while also not 'actually and formally' in things, do not result 'entirely from the mere work of reason' (DM 7.1.4/OO XXV 251). Distinctions of reasoned reason but not distinctions of reasoning reason have a foundation in reality.¹² Suárez distinguishes two potential foundations for a distinction of reasoned reason. First, such a distinction may have as its foundation the 'eminence of the very thing, which the mind thus distinguishes' (DM 7.1.4/OO XXV 251). Second, such a distinction may have as its foundation 'some relation [*habitus*] to things that are themselves truly and really distinct' (DM 7.1.4/OO XXV 251).¹³ Suárez's example is the distinction between God's justice and His mercy, which has as its foundation the eminence of God's virtue. The distinction is facilitated by inadequate concepts of God. We distinguish God's justice and His mercy 'because we do not conceive the most simple virtue of God as it is in itself and according to its whole power' (DM 7.1.5/OO XXV 251).¹⁴ Suárez's example of a distinction of reasoning reason is the distinction between Peter and himself, which occurs through repetition of the concept of Peter. Suárez

¹¹ While I have consulted Vollert's translation, translations of Suárez are my own. See Cyril Vollert (ed. and trans.), *On the Various Kinds of Distinctions* (Milwaukee: Marquette University Press, 2007).

¹² This is also how Chambers, 'Distinction', understands the distinction: 'Of this *Distinction* some Authors admit two Kinds; the one Founded, barbarously call'd *Rationis Ratiocinate*, and having some Foundation in Things . . . The other *Not-founded*, call'd *Rationis Ratiocinantis*'. The distinction is also discussed by Jean Le Clerc, *Logica, Ontologia, et Pneumatologia* (Cambridge: Awnsham and John Churchill, 1704), 220. Schmaltz offers a detailed account of Suárez's theory of distinction. See Tad Schmaltz, *The Metaphysics of the Material World: Suárez, Descartes, Spinoza* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2020), 35–47.

¹³ For discussion of the translation of *habitus* as 'relation', see Sydney Penner, 'Suárez on the Reduction of Categorical Relations', *Philosophers' Imprint*, 13 (2013), 1–24, at 3.

¹⁴ This is an example of a distinction of reasoned reason that has a foundation in eminence. But Suárez allows that relations to other, distinct things may play a part in the distinction: it may involve an 'analogy [*proportionem*] with the diverse virtues, which we find distinct in man' (DM 7.1.5/OO XXV 251). An example of a distinction of reasoned reason founded on a relation is perhaps the distinction between a line and its length, which is drawn in reference to other lines. I owe this example to an anonymous referee.

also associates rational distinction with inseparability. Separability, whether symmetric or asymmetric, is a sign of 'a greater distinction than one of reasoned reason' (*DM* 7.2.2/*OO* XXV 261).

On the one hand, there are real distinction and modal distinction, the *distinguenda* of which are, respectively, symmetrically and asymmetrically separable.¹⁵ On the other hand, there are two kinds of rational distinction, the *distinguenda* of which are inseparable: distinction of reasoned reason and distinction of reasoning reason. I consider below which of these corresponds to a Humean rational distinction. It should be noted that there is no place for modal distinctions in the *Treatise's* metaphysics of distinction. Traditionally, if the distinction between *x* and *y* is such that they are asymmetrically separable, then *x* and *y* are modally distinct. According to the separability principle, if *x* and *y* are distinct, then they are symmetrically separable. The separability principle implies that any putative modal distinction is either a real distinction or no distinction at all. Hume acknowledges this result in his discussion of the Aristotelian theory of substance and accident, which maintains 'a dependence of every quality on [an] unknown substance' (*T* 1.4.3.7). The separability principle renders this unintelligible: 'This conceit, however, is no more reasonable than any of the foregoing. Every quality being a distinct thing from another, may be conceiv'd to exist apart, and may exist apart, not only from every other quality, but from that unintelligible chimera of a substance' (*T* 1.4.3.7). The separability principle undermines the notion of modal distinction, precluding relations of metaphysical dependence between distinct items.

In addition to their being inseparable, are the *distinguenda* of a rational distinction numerically identical? Hoffman argues that, for Descartes, a rational distinction never obtains between identicals.¹⁶ This is suggested by Descartes's claim, immediately before his introducing real, modal, and rational distinction, that 'number, in things themselves, arises from the distinction between them' (*AT* VIIIA 28/*CSM* I 213).¹⁷ What, in Hume's view, is

¹⁵ Descartes cannot accept this claim without qualification. He holds that a modal distinction obtains between two modes of the same substance, where there is no asymmetric separability between these.

¹⁶ Hoffman, 'Descartes's Theory of Distinction', 60.

¹⁷ For a reading similar to Hoffman's, see Justin Skirry, 'Descartes's Conceptual Distinction and Its Ontological Import', *Journal of the History of Philosophy*, 42 (2004), 121–44. Another piece of evidence for this reading is Descartes's claiming that a rational distinction obtains between a substance and an attribute of the substance and that attributes are 'in a substance' (*AT* VIIIA 26/*CSM* I 211). Brown argues that Hoffman's reading is incompatible with Descartes's apparent identifications of a substance with its principal attribute. See Deborah Brown, 'The Duck's Leg: Descartes's Intermediate Distinction', *Midwest Studies in Philosophy*, 35 (2011),

the relation between numerical identity and rational distinction? A rational distinction would be a distinction between items that are inseparable and, by the separability principle, not distinct. Mutual inseparability and lack of distinction do not entail identity, as that relation is understood in the *Treatise*. *T* 1.4.2 provides an etiology of the idea of identity, according to which identity consists in 'the *invariableness* and *uninterruptedness* of any object, thro' a suppos'd variation of time' (*T* 1.4.2.30). Humean identity is a diachronic relation: it does not obtain between coexistent items. Inseparability and lack of distinction do not entail identity so understood because inseparable and non-distinct items that are coexistent are not, in this sense, identical. But Hume does hold that inseparability and lack of distinctness entail identity in the sense of numerical sameness, if not understood to be essentially diachronic. For example, in *T* 1.2.6's discussion of the idea of existence, he says that inseparable perceptions are really one, not two: 'I do not think there are any two distinct impressions, which are inseparably conjoin'd' (*T* 1.2.6.3).

2. Distinguishing

Hume's predecessors frequently appeal to the faculty of abstraction to explain how the mind draws rational distinctions. Descartes writes that a rational distinction is 'recognized by our inability to form a clear and distinct idea of the substance if we exclude from it the attribute in question' (AT VIIIA 30/CSM I 214). One of his examples of a rational distinction is one's considering the essence of a thing 'in abstraction' from its existence (AT IV 349/CSMK 280). Arnauld and Nicole write that one kind of abstraction 'takes place when, in the case of a single thing having different attributes, we think of one attribute without the other even though they differ only by a distinction of reason'.¹⁸ Their example is a distinction between two attributes of oneself:

26–45. See also Lawrence Nolan, 'Reductionism and Nominalism in Descartes's Theory of Attributes', *Topoi*, 16 (1997), 129–40. Rodríguez-Pereyra argues that the identity of a substance and its principal attribute, from which the substance is rationally distinct, is implied by Descartes's claim that finite substances 'need only the ordinary concurrence of God in order to exist' (AT VIIIA 24/CSM I 210). See Gonzalo Rodríguez-Pereyra, 'Descartes's Substance Dualism and His Independence Conception of Substance', *Journal of the History of Philosophy*, 46 (2008), 69–89, at 81–2.

¹⁸ Antoine Arnauld and Pierre Nicole, *Logic or the Art of Thinking*, ed. and trans. Jill Vance Buroker (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), 38. Hume refers to this discussion at *T* 1.2.4.12.

Suppose, for example, I reflect that I am thinking, and, in consequence, that I am the I who thinks. In my idea of the I who thinks, I can consider a thinking thing without noticing that it is I, although in me the I and the one who thinks are one and the same thing. The idea I thereby conceive of a person who thinks can represent not only me but all other thinking persons.¹⁹

When one reflects on one's self, one can attend to one of its properties—that it is a thinking substance—while failing to notice another—that it is *oneself*. One thereby forms an idea of the thinking substance the content of which does not include the latter property. By means of abstraction, one achieves an idea of a property as existing separately from another from which it is, in reality, inseparable.

Hume says that his account of rational distinction relies upon the *Treatise's* 'explication of abstract ideas' (*T* 1.1.7.18). But he cannot accept the abstraction strategy endorsed by these authors, according to which abstraction allows one to form an idea the content of which includes only one of two inseparable properties. First, in violation of the separability principle, the formation of such ideas amounts to one's separating in thought items that cannot be separated in reality. Hume does not restrict the scope of the separability principle, so that it does not apply to thoughts produced by abstraction. He appeals to the principle in arguing against the view that abstract ideas are 'general . . . in the mind's conception of them' (*T* 1.1.7.1). Second, at least some relevant instances of abstraction involve one's removing properties from the content of determinate ideas, so as to render them general.²⁰ In another example, Arnauld and Nicole write of one's forming an idea that 'can represent all triangles' by 'ignor[ing] all of the particular circumstances' of a triangle, such as the length of its sides. Hume opposes this theory of abstraction, arguing that it is 'utterly impossible to conceive any quantity or quality, without forming a precise notion of its degrees' (*T* 1.1.7.2).

Hume's own account of the process by which rational distinctions are drawn is provided in the closing paragraph of *T* 1.1.7:

¹⁹ Arnauld and Nicole, *Logic or the Art of Thinking*, 38.

²⁰ In other words, some relevant instances of abstraction are what Rickless calls *generalizing abstraction*. See Samuel C. Rickless, *Berkeley's Argument for Idealism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), 104. This is opposed to *singling abstraction*, which involves the mere mental separation of conjoined qualities.

[W]hen a globe of white marble is presented, we receive only the impression of a white colour dispos'd in a certain form, nor are we able to separate and distinguish the colour from the form. But observing afterwards a globe of black marble and a cube of white, and comparing them with our former object, we find two separate resemblances, in what formerly seem'd, and really is, perfectly inseparable. After a little more practice of this kind, we begin to distinguish the figure from the colour by a *distinction of reason*; that is, we consider the figure and colour together, since they are in effect the same and undistinguishable; but still view them in different aspects, according to the resemblances, of which they are susceptible. When we would consider only the figure of the globe of white marble, we form in reality an idea both of the figure and colour, but tacitly carry our eye to its resemblance with the globe of black marble: And in the same manner, when we would consider its colour only, we turn our view to its resemblance with the cube of white marble. By this means we accompany our ideas with a kind of reflection, of which custom renders us, in a great measure, insensible. (T 1.1.7.18)

Hume's example is a rational distinction between the token color and the token shape of a white globe (globe_w), which are 'in reality neither distinguishable, nor different, nor separable'.²¹ One draws a rational distinction between the color and shape of globe_w by attending to different resemblance relations in which globe_w stands. On the one hand, globe_w resembles a black globe (globe_b) with regard to shape. On the other hand, globe_w resembles a white cube (cube_w) with regard to color. To draw a rational distinction between the color and shape of globe_w , we 'tacitly carry our eye to its resemblance' to globe_b .

Hume says that 'we must have recourse to the foregoing explication of abstract ideas' to explain rational distinctions, suggesting that his treatment of such distinctions is, in some respect, dependent on the theory of general representation developed in T 1.1.7 (T 1.1.7.18). He rejects the Lockean claim that we have general ideas that are intrinsically indeterminate and provides an account of how ideas 'particular in their nature' become 'general in their representation' (T 1.1.7.10). 'White' is a general term. Associated with this term is a revival set, which, ideally, includes all and only one's ideas of white

²¹ Hume's discussion of rational distinction is concerned with rational distinctions between property-tokens. See Qu, 'Type Distinctions', for discussion of rational distinctions between property-types.

particulars. Use of 'white' calls to mind an idea of a white particular. This exemplar idea is a member of the revival set associated with 'white'.²² Also associated with 'white' is the custom of 'reviving' one or more of the other members of the revival set as needed. For any token use of 'white', the signification of the term is an idea of a white particular, accompanied by the custom of reviving other members of the revival set of 'white'. When one, on the occasion of a use of 'white', calls to mind an exemplar idea from that revival set, the idea represents the type or sort of which it is an exemplar.

In what respect does Hume's account of rational distinction depend on his theory of general ideas? The latter supports the former by undermining a rival approach to explaining rational distinctions: the abstraction-based strategy of, *inter alia*, the Port Royal logicians.²³ Some have argued that there is another relation between Hume's theory of general ideas and rational distinction. Garrett claims that Hume's account of the process underlying rational distinction is an application of the theory of general ideas:

[Hume's account of general ideas] shows how a *single* given perception may represent any one of a *number* of qualities by being associated with an appropriate class of resembling perceptions. And that is just what occurs in the case of a distinction of reason: a single perception-token functions as a perception of more than one thing.²⁴

On this reading, when one rationally distinguishes the white of globe_w from its shape, one's idea of globe_w is made to function as an exemplar of the revival set associated with 'white'.

This receives support from *T* 1.4.5, where Hume writes of 'a distinction of reason, or an abstraction' (*T* 1.4.5.26, emphasis added). Broughton raises a textual objection to it: Hume does not explicitly apply the theory of general ideas in his discussion of rational distinctions.²⁵ There is also a systematic objection. The reading implies that one's drawing a rational distinction with respect to the color of globe_w amounts to one's deploying the idea of globe_w.

²² I borrow this terminology from Garrett, *Cognition and Commitment*, 104.

²³ Hoffman notes another relation between the theory of general ideas and that of rational distinction: 'Understanding the distinction of reason does not help us understand how a particular perception can signify many things (something he has already explained [in *T* 1.1.7]); rather it explains what is really going on when people mistakenly believe they are considering colour apart from figure.' See Paul Hoffman, 'Hume on the Distinction of Reason' ['Distinction of Reason'], *British Journal for the History of Philosophy*, 19 (2011), 1131–41, at 1134.

²⁴ Garrett, *Cognition and Commitment*, 63–4.

²⁵ Broughton, 'Explaining General Ideas', 289.

as an exemplar of the revival set associated with 'white.' The idea of globe_w thereby functions as a perception of white, a property-type.²⁶ But in Hume's discussion of rational distinction, his concern is with property-tokens. For example, he writes of distinguishing 'a figure from the body figur'd' and 'the colour from the form' of globe_w (*T* 1.1.7.18, emphasis added). On the reading in view, the process underlying rational distinction has a product of the wrong kind: a thought of a property-type.²⁷

The process should instead be understood in terms of acts of comparison. Hume draws a distinction between two senses of 'relation.' A natural relation is one 'by which two ideas are connected together in the imagination, and the one naturally introduces the other' (*T* 1.1.5.1). A philosophical relation is a 'particular circumstance, in which, even upon the arbitrary union of two ideas in the fancy, we may think proper to compare them' (*T* 1.1.5.1). Thoughts of philosophical relations, one of which is resemblance, are achieved by acts of comparison.²⁸ Resemblance relations are not, in general, products of acts of comparison.²⁹ Comparison presupposes resemblance: 'no objects will admit of comparison, but what have some degree of resemblance' (*T* 1.1.5.3). Drawing a rational distinction is constituted by one's engaging in successive acts of comparison that constitute thoughts about resemblance relations, which relations exist prior to those acts. When drawing a rational distinction between the color and shape of globe_w, one compares globe_w with globe_b and finds a resemblance in respect of shape. One then compares globe_w with cube_w.³⁰ Thus, Hume writes that 'observing afterwards a globe of

²⁶ Garrett, *Cognition and Commitment*, 64.

²⁷ Ainslie notes a similar problem but does not seem to take it as a reason to abandon the reading in view. See Donald Ainslie, *Hume's True Scepticism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2015), 167n.

²⁸ Hume writes that distance is a philosophical relation because 'we acquire an idea of it by the comparing of objects' (*T* 1.1.5.1). Further, he writes that the seven philosophical relations are 'qualities, which make objects admit of comparison, and by which the ideas of philosophical relation are produced' (*T* 1.1.5.2). Beebe argues that what it is for a relation to be a philosophical relation is for it to be a subject of comparison. See Helen Beebe, 'Hume's Two Definitions: The Procedural Interpretation', *Hume Studies*, 37 (2011), 243–74.

²⁹ At *T* 1.3.14.28, Hume writes that the fact that 'like objects may be observ'd in several instances to have like relations' is 'independent of, and antecedent to the operations of the understanding'. See Baxter, 'Differential Resemblance', 180–1, for an argument that Hume countenances mind-independent resemblance. One passage suggests that no relations are mind-independent. At *T* 1.2.4.21, Hume writes: 'since equality is a relation, it is not, strictly speaking, a property in the figures themselves, but arises merely from the comparison, which the mind makes betwixt them.' Waxman argues that all philosophical relations depend for their existence on an association of ideas. See Wayne Waxman, *Hume's Theory of Consciousness* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994), 81.

³⁰ Cummins claims that, for Hume, 'words are crucial to the whole process' of drawing rational distinctions because such distinctions require one's applying general terms, such as 'color'

black marble and a cube of white, and *comparing* them with our former object, we find two separate resemblances, in what formerly seem'd, and really is, perfectly inseparable' (*T* 1.1.7.18, emphasis added). The process is initially constituted by deliberate acts of comparison. But after one has engaged repeatedly in such acts, custom—the propensity of the imagination by virtue of which 'the repetition of any particular act or operation produces a propensity to renew the same act or operation'—renders one 'insensible' to them (*EHU* 5.5; *T* 1.1.7.18).³¹

I suggest that Hume claims that his account of rational distinction has 'recourse to the foregoing explication of abstract ideas' not because he takes the former to be an application of the latter. Instead, the account of rational distinction makes use of an explanatory strategy of which the theory of general ideas is another instance. No mental content, considered in isolation from the mind's operations, represents a type or sort. General representation arises only by virtue of the conjunction of contents with an operation of the understanding: custom-based association of ideas. General ideas are explicable only by appeal to the interaction of processes with contents. The account of rational distinction has an analogous structure. Rational distinction can be understood only by appeal to the interaction of comparative processes

and 'shape'. See Phillip Cummins, 'Hume on Qualities', *Hume Studies*, 22 (1996), 49–88, at 71. I do not find evidence for this in *T* 1.1.7.18. There is a question whether Hume takes possession of general ideas to require use of general terms. Those who endorse this reading include Ainslie, *Hume's True Scepticism*, 65; Karl Schafer, 'The Artificial Virtues of Thought: Correctness and Cognition in Hume', *Philosophers' Imprint*, 19 (2019), 1–20, at 6; and Elena Gordon, 'The Developmental Potential of the Human Mind: Hume on Children and the Formation of Fiction', *British Journal for the History of Philosophy*, 31 (2023), 58–78, at 63–4. For an opposing reading, see Waxman, *Hume's Theory of Consciousness*, 105–15. I intend to remain neutral on this issue here. If general ideas are essentially linguistic, then the reading according to which drawing a rational distinction involves deployment of general ideas would imply that drawing a rational distinction requires possession of linguistic capabilities. Hume implies that possession of general ideas is not required for recognition of resemblances, writing that the first step in the formation of a general idea is one's 'hav[ing] found a resemblance among several objects' (*T* 1.1.7.7). See Henry E. Allison, *Custom and Reason in Hume: A Kantian Reading of the First Book of the Treatise* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 2008), 33.

³¹ Similarly, Hume writes that 'custom may make us insensible' to an 'emotion or movement of the spirit' that accompanies a sensory impression (*T* 2.2.8.4). For a reading of the *Treatise* that emphasizes the often hidden influence of custom, see Jay Garfield, *The Concealed Influence of Custom: Hume's Treatise from the Inside Out* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2019). Comparing globe_w with cube_w is insufficient to draw the rational distinction between the color and shape of globe_w; one must also compare globe_w with globe_b. To rationally distinguish properties *F* and *G* of an object, one must compare the object both with one that has *F* and with one that lacks *F*. This requirement is implied by Hume's argument that we cannot achieve a rational distinction between an item and its existence, which is precluded by our lacking an idea of an item that lacks existence (*T* 1.2.6.6).

of the mind with certain contents. Such contents, considered in isolation, are insufficient to ground a rational distinction. The account of rational distinction has recourse to the theory of general ideas in the sense that it deploys an explanatory strategy that Hume found indispensable for explaining general representation.

3. Distinction

What are Humean rational distinctions, and what, if anything, are they distinctions between? An answer should satisfy two constraints. First, Descartes, Chambers, and Suárez agree that a distinction is a rational distinction only if it is a distinction between items that are, in reality, inseparable. Hume also endorses this. He says that a rational distinction 'implies neither a difference nor separation' and that 'the mind would never have dream'd of distinguishing a figure from the body figur'd, as being in reality neither distinguishable, nor different, *nor separable*' (T 1.1.7.17–18, emphasis added). Further, he says that we 'distinguish the figure from the colour by a *distinction of reason*', where the figure and the color are 'in effect the same and undistinguishable' and 'perfectly inseparable' (T 1.1.7.18). This implies the *inseparability constraint*: a reading must hold that if x and y are the *distinguenda* of a Humean rational distinction, then x and y are inseparable.

Second, Hume acknowledges that rational distinctions are *prima facie* inconsistent with the separability principle:

The difficulty of explaining this distinction arises from the principle above explain'd, that *all ideas, which are different, are separable*. For it follows from thence, that if the figure be different from the body, their ideas must be separable as well as distinguishable; if they be not different, their ideas can neither be separable nor distinguishable. What then is meant by a distinction of reason, since it implies neither a difference nor separation? (T 1.1.7.17)

The existence of rational distinctions presents an objection to the separability principle. Suppose that x and y are rationally distinct:

1. If the separability principle is true, then x and y are separable iff x and y are distinct.
2. x and y are inseparable.

3. x and y are distinct.
4. Therefore, the separability principle is false.

(1) is seemingly entailed by the separability principle. (2) is implied by the inseparability constraint. (3) appears to follow from the claim that rational distinctions are distinctions. An account of Humean rational distinctions must explain why Hume is entitled to reject at least one premise of this argument, thereby explaining how rational distinctions are consistent with the separability principle. I call this the *consistency constraint*.

When discussing the distinction between the color and shape of globe_w, Hume writes that we ‘view them in different aspects’ (*T* 1.1.7.18). This suggests that Humean rational distinctions are distinctions between inseparable features or aspects of an object. Broughton claims that when making rational distinctions, we distinguish ‘a feature of an object when the feature is inseparable from others.’³² According to Garrett, when one draws a rational distinction between the color and shape of globe_w, one has numerically identical perceptions of the color and the shape; the distinction is ‘not a distinction between two different *perceptions* or *objects*’. Rather, when one draws this rational distinction, one ‘distinguish[es] two aspects of *one* perception-token.’³³ The aspect reading implies that Humean rational distinctions are distinctions of reasoned reason: they have as their foundation the non-identity of aspects of resemblance.

This satisfies the consistency constraint. Recall (1) of the argument against the separability principle: if the separability principle is true, then x and y are separable just in case x and y are distinct. According to the aspect reading, if x and y are rationally distinct, then this premise is false because the separability principle does not apply to aspects but rather only to perceptions and objects. Garrett writes: ‘aspects of resemblance are not themselves things or “objects”, and so they are not within the intended scope of Hume’s principle.’³⁴ Because aspects are not within the scope of the principle, Hume may hold that they are distinct and distinguishable but inseparable. This satisfies the inseparability constraint: the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions are

³² Broughton, ‘Explaining General Ideas’, 284.

³³ Garrett, *Cognition and Commitment*, 63. See also Magri, *Hume’s Imagination*, 135; Mandelbaum, ‘Distinguishable and Separable’, 245; Della Rocca, ‘Playing with Fire’, 473; and Durland, ‘First Principle’, 112–13. Baxter, ‘Differential Resemblance’, 156–7, holds that rational distinctions involve ‘respects of similarity’. While Garrett appeals to aspects, he sometimes suggests a different view, according to which the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions are revival sets associated with general terms. I consider such readings later.

³⁴ Garrett, *Cognition and Commitment*, 64.

distinct and distinguishable but inseparable. The aspect reading is tenable only if aspects of resemblance are not within the scope of the separability principle.

Hume does sometimes imply that the principle's scope is restricted to objects. For example, he says: 'whatever objects are different are distinguishable, and ... whatever objects are distinguishable are separable by the thought and imagination' (T 1.1.7.3). But he often uses 'object' in a wide sense, such that it refers to any existent whatever.³⁵ Moreover, not every statement of the separability principle restricts its application. In the Appendix, Hume writes: '*Whatever* is distinct, is distinguishable; and *whatever* is distinguishable, is separable by the thought or imagination' (T App 12, emphasis added). Likewise, he says: '*What* consists of parts is distinguishable into them, and *what* is distinguishable is separable' (T 1.2.1.3). These passages suggest that every existent is within the principle's scope.³⁶

Further, Hume applies the separability principle to 'circumstances of resemblance', which seem equivalent to aspects. In a footnote added in the Appendix, he writes: 'And of this we may be certain, even from the very abstract terms *simple idea*. They comprehend all simple ideas under them. These resemble each other in their simplicity. And yet from their very nature, which excludes all composition, this circumstance, in which they resemble, is not distinguishable nor separable from the rest' (T 1.1.7.7n).³⁷ Hume argues that aspects of resemblance are indistinguishable and inseparable from the fact that they are not distinct. This assumes that aspects are within the scope of the separability principle. The aspect reading claims that aspects of resemblance are distinct and distinguishable. If aspects are within the scope of the separability principle, then the reading implies, in violation of the inseparability constraint, that the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions are separable.

³⁵ Grene identifies at least three senses of 'object' present in the *Treatise*. See Marjorie Grene, 'The Objects of Hume's *Treatise*', *Hume Studies*, 20 (1994), 163–77.

³⁶ See also T 1.4.5.5: 'every thing, which is different, is distinguishable, and every thing which is distinguishable, is separable by the imagination.'

³⁷ Hoffman, 'Distinction of Reason', 1139, also discusses this passage in criticizing Garrett. Garrett, *Cognition and Commitment*, 63, suggests that the footnote was added to clarify Hume's view that not all aspects of resemblance are 'objects', in the sense present in T 1.1.7's statement of the separability principle. The footnote seems to be a response to a criticism raised by Hutcheson. In a 1740 letter to Hutcheson, Hume reports: 'I shall consider more carefully all the Particulars you mention to me; tho' with regard to *abstract Ideas*, tis with Difficulty I can entertain a Doubt on that head, notwithstanding your Authority. Our conversation together has furnish'd me a hint, with which I shall augment the 2d Edition.' See J. Y. T. Greig (ed.), *The Letters of David Hume*, vol. 1 (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1932), 39. Hutcheson's criticism, Hume goes on to indicate, was that Hume cannot explain how different simple ideas resemble one another.

The aspect reading holds that aspects of resemblance are inseparable but distinguishable. Two passages suggest that the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions are not distinguishable. First, *T* 1.4.5 uses Bayle's arguments against Spinoza's monism to undermine the claim that the mind is an immaterial substance. Hume argues against the suggestion that his arguments can be avoided if thought is understood as an action of the mind: 'By an action we mean much the same thing, as what is commonly call'd an *abstract mode*; that is, something, which, properly speaking, is neither distinguishable, nor separable from its substance, and is only conceiv'd by a distinction of reason, or an abstraction' (*T* 1.4.5.26). There is a rational distinction between an abstract mode and its substance, but these are neither distinguishable nor separable. Second, one of Hume's examples of a rational distinction is 'the distinction betwixt figure and the body figur'd' (*T* 1.1.7.17). He says: 'Tis certain that the mind wou'd never have dream'd of distinguishing a figure from the body figur'd, as being in reality neither distinguishable, nor different, nor separable' (*T* 1.1.7.18). There is a rational distinction between a body and its figure. Again, these are neither distinguishable nor separable. Against the aspect reading's claim that rational distinctions are distinctions between inseparable but distinguishable aspects, both passages imply the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions are indistinguishable.³⁸

It might seem that distinct aspects are required by Hume's position that objects stand in mind-independent resemblance relations: the resemblance between globe_w and globe_b is explained by each object's having numerically distinct but resembling shape-aspects.³⁹ The commitment to real resemblances does not require that all resemblance relations be explained in this way. An alternative is that some resemblance relations are primitive, not explained by further facts involving their relata. This is a qualified version of what Loux calls 'austere nominalism', according to which 'agreement in attribute [is] a fundamental and unanalyzable feature of the world.'⁴⁰ Hume's allowing that some resemblance relations are primitive is suggested by the Appendix footnote:

³⁸ An additional problem for the aspect reading is that it does not fit all of Hume's examples of rational distinction, one of which is the distinction between 'figure and the body figur'd' (*T* 1.1.7.17).

³⁹ As I read Garrett, this account of resemblance is not included in his version of the aspect reading of Humean rational distinctions. The account bears some similarity to the trope theory developed by Williams, according to which the partial resemblance of globe_w to globe_b is founded on their having exactly resembling abstract parts. See D. C. Williams, 'The Elements of Being', in A. R. J. Fisher (ed.), *The Elements and Patterns of Being: Essays in Metaphysics* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018), 24–50.

⁴⁰ Michael Loux, *Metaphysics*, 4th edition (New York: Routledge, 2017), 51.

Blue and *green* are different simple ideas, but are more resembling than blue and scarlet; tho' their perfect simplicity excludes all possibility of separation or distinction. 'Tis the same case with particular sounds, and tastes and smells. These admit of infinite resemblances upon the general appearance and comparison, without having any common circumstance the same. (*T* 1.1.7.7n)

The resemblance relations that obtain between, for example, different tastes are not explained by their having 'circumstances' in common. This suggests that not all resemblance relations are explained by a further fact involving the resembling objects.⁴¹

Hume holds that drawing a rational distinction requires attending to resemblance relations. A different reading holds that these are the *distinguenda* of a Humean rational distinction.⁴² Globe_w and globe_b resemble each other with regard to shape. Globe_w and cube_w resemble each other with regard to color. According to the relation reading, the truth of these claims is not explained by globe_w having distinct aspects, one of which explains its resembling globe_b , the other of which explains its resembling cube_w . The color and shape of globe_w are not distinct. But globe_w stands in at least two

⁴¹ Hume's holding that some resemblance relations are primitive provides an answer to an objection raised by Baxter, 'Differential Resemblance', 171–4. As Baxter reads him, Hume holds that there is a respect (color) in which globe_w resembles cube_w , and a respect (shape) in which globe_w does not resemble cube_w . Given that the color-respect and shape-respect of globe_w are inseparable, they are identical. Thus, absurdly, the respect in which globe_w resembles cube_w is also the respect in which globe_w does not resemble cube_w . Baxter's problem arises only if the resemblance_{color} of globe_w to cube_w (a relation) implies that there is some respect belonging to globe_w in which it resembles cube_w . If Hume holds that the resemblance_{color} between globe_w and cube_w is primitive, then he need not allow that the resemblance_{color} between globe_w and cube_w implies that there exists in globe_w a color-respect in which it resembles cube_w . If the resemblance_{color} is primitive, then there need not be respects of globe_w and cube_w that ground the relation. See also James Van Cleve, "'Distinction of Reason' Is an Incomplete Symbol" ['Incomplete Symbol'], *Hume Studies*, 44 (2018), 159–66, at 163, and Okamura, 'Distinctions of Reason', 433.

⁴² Okamura, 'Distinctions of Reason', 435, seems to accept that the *distinguenda* of Humean rational distinctions are resemblance relations: 'Distinctions of reason are distinctions of different kinds of resemblance.' See also Okamura, 'Distinctions of Reason', 431: 'Distinctions of reason are, at the root, different kinds of resemblances.' Okamura, 'Distinctions of Reason', 432, also claims that distinctions of reason are 'based on the contrast between different kinds of resemblances.' This suggests a weaker thesis: rational distinctions are drawn in reference to resemblance relations. This thesis is not the target of the objections that I raise below and is, in one respect, unproblematic: Hume clearly holds that rational distinctions are drawn in reference to resemblance relations. But it does not answer important questions concerning Humean rational distinctions: what, if anything, are rational distinctions distinctions between, and how are such distinctions consistent with the separability principle? Okamura, 'Distinctions of Reason', 430n, allows that some resemblance relations are grounded in the relata's having common aspects or respects.

resemblance relations: resemblance with regard to shape (resemblance_{shape}) and resemblance with regard to color (resemblance_{color}). Drawing a rational distinction is constituted by one's attending to the different resemblance relations in which globe_w stands, and these relations are the *distinguenda* of the distinction.

This does not satisfy the consistency constraint. Because the relation reading holds that the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions are distinct resemblance relations, it accepts premise (3) of the argument against the separability principle, according to which any rationally distinct items *x* and *y* are distinct. According to premise (1), if the separability principle is true, then *x* and *y* are separable just in case *x* and *y* are distinct. If the relation reading rejects (1), then it holds that the scope of the separability principle is restricted, so that the principle does not apply to the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions. But Hume places no restriction on the scope of the separability principle. According to premise (2), *x* and *y* are inseparable. If the relation reading rejects (2), then it holds that the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions are separable and, therefore, violates the inseparability constraint. To satisfy the consistency constraint, the relation reading must, against textual evidence, restrict the scope of the separability principle or, in violation of the inseparability constraint, hold that the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions are separable.

Further, the relation reading does not satisfy the inseparability constraint. The reading holds that the *distinguenda* of the rational distinction concerning globe_w are the resemblance_{shape} that obtains between globe_w and globe_b and the resemblance_{color} that obtains between globe_w and cube_w. Relations depend for their existence on the existence of their relata. The resemblance_{shape} depends for its existence on the existence of globe_w and globe_b, and the resemblance_{color} depends for its existence on globe_w and cube_w. Because globe_w, globe_b, and cube_w are distinct and, therefore, separable, this is metaphysically possible: globe_w and globe_b exist, but cube_w does not. In this case, the resemblance_{color} does not exist; but the resemblance_{shape} does exist. The resemblance_{shape} and the resemblance_{color} are separable. In violation of the inseparability constraint, the reading implies that the *distinguenda* of rational distinctions are separable.

A third reading maintains that the *distinguenda* of Humean rational distinctions are general ideas. Qu writes that 'distinctions of reason are distinctions between general ideas'. He continues: 'We can indeed distinguish between the general ideas of colour and extension, but this is merely a distinction between classes of perceptions, which are both separable and

distinguishable—considered as white, a white marble will bring to mind white objects; considered as spherical, it will bring to mind spherical objects.⁴³ The *distinguenda* of the rational distinction concerning globe_w are the revival set of the general idea associated with ‘shape’ and the revival set of the general idea associated with ‘color’, each of which includes the idea of globe_w. The general ideas reading would satisfy the consistency constraint by rejecting (2) of the argument against the separability principle, according to which the *distinguenda* of a rational distinction are inseparable. With respect to the rational distinction concerning globe_w, the general idea of color and the general idea of shape have different and, hence, separable revival sets. This precludes the general ideas reading’s satisfying the inseparability constraint. Further, while Hume does say that his account of rational distinction is dependent on the theory of general ideas, he gives no indication that what one distinguishes when drawing a rational distinction are general ideas or their revival sets.

4. Illusion

One kind of skepticism present in the *Treatise* is conceptual skepticism. Fogelin writes that this kind of skepticism ‘challenges the very intelligibility of a system of beliefs.’⁴⁴ Instances of Hume’s conceptual skepticism conclude that we do not have ideas—and, hence, cannot *think*—of certain items. For example, he argues that ‘the question concerning the substance of the soul’ is ‘absolutely unintelligible’ because we have no idea of substance (*T* 1.4.5.33). This kind of skepticism faces an objection: if, as conceptual skepticism maintains, we lack certain ideas, why do we take ourselves to have them? A version of this objection is raised by Hume’s discussion of the ancient philosophy, whose appeals to faculties and occult qualities are ‘entirely incomprehensible’ (*T* 1.4.3.8). The fact that ancient philosophers speak and reason as if they have ideas of faculties and occult qualities might seem to establish that they do have such ideas. Hume’s response to objections such as this is to identify

⁴³ Qu, ‘Type Distinctions’, 93. Qu attributes this reading to Garrett. Garrett, *Cognition and Commitment*, 64, writes: ‘to speak of distinguishing such “aspects” or “resemblances” is merely a way of referring to the genuine distinction we find between the many different—but also distinguishable and separable—classes of perceptions that resemble the perceptions under discussion.’ Qu, ‘Type Distinctions’, 94, does not seem to ultimately endorse the general ideas reading, writing that ‘token distinctions of reason distinguish particular instances that seem inseparable.’

⁴⁴ Robert Fogelin, *Hume’s Skepticism in the Treatise of Human Nature* (New York: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1985), 6.

an illusion that leads us to suppose that we can achieve thoughts that are not within our capacity. The ancient philosophers are led by their repeated uses of 'faculty' and 'occult quality' to suppose that they possess ideas signified by those terms (*T* 1.4.3.10).⁴⁵ A product of this illusion is semantic blindness: we are mistaken about the meanings of 'faculty' and 'occult quality', taking them to signify ideas that we lack.

My thesis is that Hume's account of rational distinction pursues a similar strategy. The account is framed by a question: 'What then is meant by a distinction of reason, since it implies neither a difference nor separation?' (*T* 1.1.7.17). What Hume initially provides is not, it seems, an answer to that question but rather an account of the cognitive process underlying rational distinction, according to which it is constituted by acts of comparison. The final sentence of *T* 1.1.7 returns to the question of the meaning of 'rational distinction': 'A person, who desires us to consider the figure of a globe of white marble without thinking on its colour, desires an impossibility; but *his meaning is*, that we should consider the colour and figure together, but still keep in our eye the resemblance to the globe of black marble' (*T* 1.1.7.18, emphasis added). I propose that this passage answers the framing question of Hume's account of rational distinction. The meaning of 'rational distinction' is the cognitive process detailed in *T* 1.1.7's closing paragraph.⁴⁶

Propositions concerning rational distinctions are made true by facts about cognitive processes. 'There is a rational distinction between the color and shape of globe_w' is made true by one's engaging in acts of comparison with respect to globe_w, globe_b, and cube_w identified in *T* 1.1.7. Locke says that 'Words in their primary or immediate Signification, stand for nothing but the Ideas in the Mind of him that uses them' (*E* III.ii.2, emphasis removed). Hume is sometimes understood to accept the Lockean thesis that a term is meaningful just in case it signifies an idea.⁴⁷ For example, he claims that 'any

⁴⁵ A similar illusion is discussed at *T* 1.2.5.21, where Hume claims that 'tis usual for men to use words for ideas, and to talk instead of thinking in their reasonings'. Another version of the objection in view is raised explicitly by Hume in his discussion of vacuum, of which, in his view, we have no idea: 'tis impossible men could so long reason about a vacuum, and either refute or defend it, without having a notion of what they refuted or defended' (*T* 1.2.5.2). Hume pursues a similar strategy in that case: we take ourselves to have an idea of empty extension because of the imagination's confusing two ideas, neither of which is itself an idea of a vacuum (*T* 1.2.5.21).

⁴⁶ This is denied by Van Cleve, according to whom Hume 'assigns no referent' to the phrase 'rational distinction between *x* and *y*'. See Van Cleve, 'Incomplete Symbol', 160. My claim that the meaning of 'rational distinction' is a cognitive process is not intended as a general thesis concerning the semantics of terms involved in cognitive illusions.

⁴⁷ Rosenberg writes that terms that do not signify ideas derived from impressions are 'meaningless noises'. See Alexander Rosenberg, 'Hume's Philosophy of Science', in David Fate Norton

philosophical term [that] has no idea annexed to it . . . is altogether insignificant' (*T* Abs 7). My proposal with respect to 'rational distinction' implies that, for Hume, not all meaningful terms signify an idea; some signify cognitive processes. In countenancing such exceptions, Hume follows Locke, according to whom some terms—particles, such as 'is', 'not', and 'and'—are not signs of ideas but rather 'marks of some Action, or Intimation of the Mind' (*E* III.vii.4, emphasis removed).

According to the separability principle, distinction entails distinguishability and separability. As used in the principle, 'distinction' means a numerical difference between items. This is the sense of 'distinction' as used by Chambers, according to whom it is 'a Diversity of Things or Conceptions.'⁴⁸ Likewise, Descartes writes that a distinction gives rise to 'number' in things (*AT* VIIIA 28/*CSM* I 213). Hume concludes the taxonomy of relations offered in *T* 1.1.5, 'Of relations', with a discussion of difference, of which there are two kinds: 'The first is call'd a difference of *number*; the other of *kind*' (*T* 1.1.5.10). The distinctness salient to the separability principle is numerical difference. In one use of the principle, Hume writes that '[w]hat consists of parts is distinguishable into them, and what is distinguishable is separable' (*T* 1.2.1.3). An object's having a plurality of parts is taken to imply that the item is composed of parts that are distinguishable and separable. Because plurality requires numerical difference, this use of the separability principle takes the numerical difference of the parts of a whole to be sufficient for the distinguishability and separability of the parts. A distinction in what I call the *proper sense* is a distinction between items that are numerically non-identical: many, not one.

Hume's account of rational distinction holds that claims about rational distinctions are meaningful and sometimes true. But it is not an account of distinctions, if 'distinction' is used in the proper sense. There being a rational distinction between the color and shape of globe_w, amounts to one's engaging in successive acts of comparison involving globe_w. This does not correspond to a difference between the color and shape of globe_w; the color and the shape

(ed.), *The Cambridge Companion to Hume* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993), 64–89, at 66. By contrast, Strawson claims that 'Hume's theory of ideas was never put forward as a completely general theory of meaning or content'. See Galen Strawson, *The Evident Connexion: Hume on Personal Identity* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2011), 6. For discussion of Hume's theory of meaning, see Walter Ott, 'Hume on Meaning', *Hume Studies*, 32 (2006), 233–252.

⁴⁸ Chambers, 'Distinction'.

are numerically the same. Humean rational distinctions are not distinctions in the proper sense of 'distinction'. They are not distinctions in the sense that is salient to the separability principle. This satisfies the inseparability constraint. Because rational distinctions are not distinctions in the proper sense salient to the separability principle, the rational distinction between the color and shape of globe_w does not imply their distinguishability.⁴⁹ The color and shape of globe_w are not properly distinct and, hence, are not distinguishable. One does not distinguish them in drawing a rational distinction between them. The color and the shape are the *distinguenda* of this rational distinction only insofar as one *takes oneself* to distinguish them. Further, because the color and shape are not properly distinct, they are inseparable in thought and in reality.⁵⁰

Whereas a distinction of reasoned reason has some foundation in reality, a distinction of reasoning reason has no foundation in reality. Humean rational distinctions are distinctions of reasoned reason.⁵¹ Tokens of the process-type explained in *T* 1.1.7 are constituted by one's attending, by means of comparison, to resemblance relations that obtain among objects and perceptions: they are 'founded on the different resemblances, which the same simple idea may have to several different ideas' (*T* 1.2.6.6). These resemblance relations are themselves properly distinct and obtain independently of acts of comparing. The comparisons that constitute Humean rational distinctions are made in reference to real relations of resemblance between which there is a numerical difference. Such distinctions have a foundation *in*

⁴⁹ Hakkarainen, 'Third Type of Distinction', 62, holds that the scope of the separability principle is restricted, such that the principle applies only to real distinctions. My claim is that Hume holds that any genuine distinction implies and is implied by separability and distinguishability. Rationally distinct items are not properly distinct, and so they are neither distinguishable nor separable. Della Rocca, 'Playing with Fire', 473, holds that Humean rational distinctions are not distinctions in the sense salient to Cartesian real distinction.

⁵⁰ Hume's account is not, on this reading, an account of how a thinker succeeds in, for example, thinking of the globe's color separately from its shape. That thought would imply, in violation of the separability principle, that the color and the shape are separable in thought but not properly distinct.

⁵¹ Humean rational distinctions are most similar to Suárez's second kind of distinction of reasoned reason, which have as their foundation some relation to distinct things. Hume does not accept all aspects of Suárez's account of distinctions of reasoned reason. Suárez indicates that distinctions of reasoned reason involve inadequate concepts: 'But truly the latter distinction of reason obtains through inadequate concepts of the same thing' (DM 7.1.5/OO XXV 251). Hume offers no reason to suppose that we cannot draw rational distinctions concerning objects of which we have adequate ideas, such as rational distinctions concerning 'the most minute parts of extension' (*T* 1.2.1.1).

re insofar as they are drawn in reference to items that are, in reality, properly distinct.

While Humean rational distinctions are constituted by one's successively attending to distinct resemblance relations, such distinctions cannot, in view of the inseparability constraint, be understood as distinctions the *distinguenda* of which are resemblance relations. A distinction between resemblance relations, unlike a rational distinction, is a distinction in the proper sense: it is a distinction between entities that are numerically distinct and, hence, separable. A distinction between resemblance relations has *distinguenda* in the sense that it is a distinction between numerically different relations that one, in drawing the distinction, succeeds in distinguishing. By contrast, the items between which a rational distinction is drawn—the color and shape of globe_w—are neither properly distinct nor distinguishable. Further, because a distinction between resemblance relations is a distinction between numerically different relations that obtain among objects, propositions concerning distinctions between resemblance relations—‘There is a distinction between globe_w’s resemblance to cube_w and its resemblance to globe_b’—have as their truth-makers numerical differences between relations that obtain among objects. Propositions concerning a distinction between resemblance relations do not depend for their truth on facts involving a thinker who distinguishes the relations. By contrast, while rational distinction requires attending to numerically different resemblance relations, the existence of such relations is not sufficient for the truth of propositions concerning rational distinctions. Propositions concerning rational distinctions—‘There is a rational distinction between the color and shape of globe_w’—have as their truth-makers occurrences of a cognitive process.

Recall the argument against the separability principle:

1. If the separability principle is true, then x and y are separable iff x and y are distinct.
2. x and y are inseparable.
3. x and y are distinct.
4. Therefore, the separability principle is false.

This argument equivocates. If ‘distinct’ is used in the proper sense, (1) is true because the separability principle implies that, for any existent, distinction, in the proper sense, implies and is implied by separability. But (3) is false: there being a rational distinction between, for example, the color and shape

of globe_w amounts to one's engaging in acts of comparison with respect to globe_w. The occurrence of this process does not imply that the color and shape of globe_w are distinct, in the proper sense. If 'distinct' is used in the sense salient to rational distinction, then (3) is true but (1) is false: the separability principle does not imply that there is a biconditional relationship between separability and distinction in that sense. Hume's account of rational distinctions shows the argument against the separability principle to be unsound without requiring restriction of the scope of the separability principle.

The account also explains why the argument against the separability principle is initially compelling. To engage in the successive acts of comparison that constitute rational distinction is not itself to succumb to an illusion. If one asserts that there is a rational distinction between the color and shape of globe_w upon successively comparing globe_w with globe_b and cube_w, one's assertion is true. But repetition of this process leads to an illusion, generating the false supposition that inseparable items are properly distinct and distinguishable:

After a little more practice of this kind, we begin to distinguish the figure from the colour by a *distinction of reason*; that is, we consider the figure and colour together, since they are in effect the same and undistinguishable; but still view them in different aspects, according to the resemblances, of which they are susceptible. . . . By this means we accompany our ideas with a kind of reflection, *of which custom renders us, in a great measure, insensible*. (T 1.1.7.18, emphasis added)

The acts of comparison that constitute rational distinction become customary. The concealing effect of custom is such that one becomes unaware that this is all that one is doing when one draws a rational distinction. One is thereby led to suppose that one has distinguished items that are inseparable. By virtue of one's successively comparing globe_w with globe_b and cube_w, one is led to suppose that one can distinguish the color and shape of globe_w and, accordingly, that these are properly distinct, distinguishable, and separable. This illusion disposes one to accept a premise of the argument against the separability principle that should be denied: that rationally distinct items are (properly) distinct and, hence, distinguishable.⁵² The illusion causes one to

⁵² Some commentators have suggested that Hume employs rational distinctions in his own theorizing, although Hume never describes himself as having engaged in rational distinction. Qu suggests that Hume's distinction between the intentionality and qualitative character of indirect passions can be understood as a rational distinction. See Hsueh Qu, 'The Simple

reason and speak as if inseparable items were distinct and distinguishable. And just as the illusion concerning faculties and occult qualities results in semantic blindness concerning 'faculty' and 'occult quality', the illusion produced by rational distinction causes one to mistake the meaning of 'rational distinction'.⁵³

5. Conclusion

Hume's account of rational distinction is not an explanation of how we succeed in drawing distinctions between inseparable items but rather an identification of an illusion that leads one to suppose that such distinctions are possible. That account, like all instances of skepticism, aims to show that certain cognitive achievements are merely apparent. There is a significant analogy with the *Treatise's* treatment of causal necessity. Hume concludes that when 'power' and 'necessity' are used to refer to items external to the mind, they 'lose their true meaning by being *wrong apply'd*' (T 1.3.14.14). Causal necessity is instead identified with the mind's 'transition arising from the accustom'd union' of the ideas of causes and effects (T 1.3.14.21).⁵⁴

Duality: Humean Passions', *Canadian Journal of Philosophy*, 42 (2012), 98–116, at 109–10. The present reading does not preclude this, holding that propositions concerning rational distinction may be true, provided that one has engaged in the successive comparisons that constitute rational distinction. But repetition of that process produces the false supposition that inseparable items are properly distinct and distinguishable. Insofar as Hume forms that supposition, he succumbs to a cognitive illusion. Hume does sometimes adopt commitments that are, by his own principles, illusory. His account of the passions arguably presupposes the identity of persons over time, an illusion produced by the associative propensities of the imagination. Further, Books 2 and 3 arguably presuppose a commitment to the continued and distinct existence of body, which might be understood to have been shown to be illusory by T 1.4.2, 'Of scepticism with regard to the senses'.

⁵³ The first sentence of the *Treatise's* discussion of rational distinction suggests that this illusion is endemic among philosophers: 'Before I leave this subject I shall employ the same principles to explain that distinction of reason, which is so much talk'd of, and is so little understood, in the schools' (T 1.1.7.17). The only passages outside of T 1.1.7 in which rational distinctions are explicitly mentioned concern philosophical topics: a rational distinction between length and breadth (T 1.2.4.12); a rational distinction between thought, understood as an action or 'abstract mode', and a substance (T 1.4.5.26); and a rational distinction between the idea of an item and the idea of that item's existence (T 1.2.6.6). This evidence is compatible with Hume's holding that the vulgar participate in rational distinction and the accompanying illusion.

⁵⁴ Hume writes in the Abstract of the *Treatise*: 'Upon the whole, then, either we have no idea at all of force and energy, and these words are altogether insignificant, or they can mean nothing but that determination of the thought, acquir'd by habit, to pass from the cause to its usual effect' (T Abs 26). At T 2.3.2.4, Hume allows that necessity may also be defined as 'the constant union and conjunction of like objects'. See Peter Millican, 'Hume as Regularity Theorist—After All! Completing a Counter-Revolution', *Hume Studies*, 49 (2024), 101–62, at 126–9.

Because this customary transition is ‘the same with the power and necessity’, the meaning of ‘causal necessity’, like, as I have argued, the meaning of ‘rational distinction’, is a process of the human understanding (*T* 1.3.14.24).⁵⁵

Indiana University, Bloomington

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